

Psalms 56

What Time I Am Afraid

What time I am afraid, I will trust in thee
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Be merciful unto me, O God: for man would swallow me up; he fighting daily oppresseth me.*
- 2 *Mine enemies would daily swallow me up: for they be many that fight against me, O thou most High.*
- 3 *What time I am afraid, I will trust in thee.*
- 4 *In God I will praise his word, in God I have put my trust; I will not fear what flesh can do unto me.*
- 5 *Every day they wrest my words: all their thoughts are against me for evil.*
- 6 *They gather themselves together, they hide themselves, they mark my steps, when they wait for my soul.*
- 7 *Shall they escape by iniquity? in thine anger cast down the people, O God.*
- 8 *Thou tellest my wanderings: put thou my tears into thy bottle: are they not in thy book?*
- 9 *When I cry unto thee, then shall mine enemies turn back: this I know; for God is for me.*
- 10 *In God will I praise his word: in the LORD will I praise his word.*
- 11 *In God have I put my trust: I will not be afraid what man can do unto me.*
- 12 *Thy vows are upon me, O God: I will render praises unto thee.*
- 13 *For thou hast delivered my soul from death: wilt not thou deliver my feet from falling, that I may walk before God in the light of the living?*

2 · CONTEXT

Superscription recalls when the Philistines took David in Gath (1 Sam 21:10–15), a time of real physical danger and fear. Henry admires the psalm's repeated refrain turning fear directly into trust rather than denying fear exists. MacArthur-style notes highlight verse 8's tender image of God recording tears "in a bottle," showing intimate divine attentiveness to suffering.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

"Be merciful unto me, O God: for man would swallow me up... What time I am afraid, I will trust in thee." Constant pressure from enemies who "wrest" his words does not stop him from choosing trust as his default response to fear, since "in God I will praise his word."

Verse 5-7

They mark his steps and wait for his soul as those lying in wait; David asks God to render judgment on such wickedness, refusing to let their scheming go unanswered before God.

Verse 8-11

Tender assurance: "Thou tellest my wanderings: put my tears into thy bottle: are they not in thy book?" God's intimate record of suffering grounds renewed confidence: "In God have I put my trust: I will not be afraid what man can do unto me."

Verse 12-13

Vows made in distress will be paid in praise, for God "hast delivered my soul from death"—not merely from danger, but so he may "walk before God in the light of the living."

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Fear and trust are not mutually exclusive; the mature response to real danger is naming the fear honestly and then deliberately choosing trust, resting on the fact that God notices and records every tear.

Application for life today.

When afraid, do not pretend otherwise—say "I am afraid" honestly to God, then add David's resolve: "I will trust in thee." Let the truth that God keeps your tears "in a bottle" shape how you process grief; nothing is wasted or unseen. Follow through on vows made in crisis once deliverance comes, rather than letting gratitude fade with the danger.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What situation currently makes you say, "What time I am afraid"—and how could you consciously add "I will trust in thee"?

2. How does it change your view of suffering to know God "tellect" your wanderings and keeps your tears "in a bottle"?

3. Is there a vow or promise you made to God in a hard season that you still need to fulfill now that relief has come?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).